

Female Sexual Dysfunction

Patient Information · Common, often treatable concerns about sex

WARWIKI

Female sexual dysfunction means ongoing problems with **desire, arousal, orgasm, or pain with sex** that bother you. It is common at every age. There is usually more than one cause, and it is often treatable. It is a normal medical topic to raise, and your team can help.

About This Condition

Concerns usually fall into one or more areas:

- **Desire:** low interest in sex
- **Arousal:** trouble becoming or staying aroused, or dryness
- **Orgasm:** trouble reaching climax
- **Pain:** pain during or after sex, or trouble with penetration

What Causes It

Often a mix of things:

- **Menopause and low estrogen**, which cause vaginal dryness and thinning
- **Tight or painful pelvic floor muscles**, prolapse, or worry about leaking urine
- Health problems, past surgery, and some **medicines**, such as some antidepressants and birth control pills
- Stress, mood, sleep and relationship issues

Learn the Terms

Libido

Sexual desire or interest.

Arousal

The body's physical response, including wetness.

Dyspareunia

Pain during or after sex.

GSM

Genitourinary syndrome of menopause: dryness and thinning from low estrogen.

Vaginal estrogen

A low-dose treatment placed in the vagina for dryness and pain.

Pelvic floor therapy

Physical therapy for pain from tight pelvic muscles.

Sex therapy

Talk therapy, alone or with a partner, focused on sexual concerns.

Is this “all in my head”? No. There are real physical causes, such as dryness, a tight pelvic floor, prolapse or side effects of medicine. Feelings and relationships matter too. A good checkup looks at all of these, and many people get better.

How It's Checked

- A private talk about your concerns and history
- An exam to look for physical causes, such as dryness, tight muscles or prolapse
- A review of your medicines and overall health

How It's Treated

- **Dryness and pain:** lubricants and moisturizers. For dryness after menopause, **vaginal estrogen** or other vaginal treatments.
- **Pelvic floor physical therapy** for pain or tight muscles.
- **Treat what adds to it:** prolapse, leaking, or medicines that lower desire. Do not stop an antidepressant on your own; ask first.
- **Talk therapy:** sex therapy, couples therapy or mindfulness.
- **Medicines for low desire:** a pill or an injection for some women, and testosterone for some after menopause. The benefit is modest, and each has side effects.

Helpful Steps

- Use a **lubricant** during sex and a **moisturizer** regularly for dryness.
- Talking openly with your partner can ease pressure.
- Give treatments time. Using more than one often works best.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- New pain, or a **lump** in the vulva or vagina
- Bleeding after sex or after menopause
- Any worry about your safety in a relationship

Go to an emergency department if:

- You have heavy vaginal bleeding, such as soaking a pad an hour
- You are in danger or have been hurt
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. Problems with desire, arousal, orgasm or pain are common and often treatable.
2. Many causes are physical, and feelings and relationships matter too.
3. It is worth raising with your team.